> of an olive complexion, with a thick black beard. The expression of his countenance was dignified and pleasing, his voice clear, his address princely. We thought at first that he had on an armour of jewels; but, on close inspection, we found this to be a mistake, and his real dress to consist of a green tunic, with large flowers in gold and precious stones, over which were a large breastplate of diamonds, shaped like two flattened *fleur de lis*, an ornament of the same kind on each thigh, large emerald bracelets on the arms and many other jewels in different places. In one of the bracelets was the Koh-i-Nur . . . It will scarcely be believed of an Eastern monarch, how much he had the manners of a gentleman, or how well he preserved his dignity, while he seemed only anxious to please.[38]

Yet the best, and certainly the fullest, record of this first meeting of the Afghans and the British was written not by Elphinstone, but by a junior member of his staff. William Fraser was a young Persian scholar from Inverness and the letter he wrote back to his parents in the Highlands, wide-eyed with wonder at the reception given by the Shah, provides the sharpest-focused and most palpable image that survives of Shuja at the peak of his power. Fraser described the magnificent procession that escorted the British officers in their frogged and braided pigeon-tailcoats through the streets of Peshawar. They passed crowds of Afghan men in flowing mantles and caps of black sheepskin, while some of their women, unlike the unveiled peasants of the country, wore full-length white burkhas, a novel sight for the British.

The British were summoned through the outer courts of Peshawar's great fortress named, like that in Kabul, the Bala Hisar. They were marched past the King's elephants and pet tiger, 'which was by far the finest object of what might be called the palace yard', and found themselves in the main courtyard in front of the hall of audience. In the middle, three fountains on different levels were playing, 'throwing up the liquid in a thin mist to a considerable height'. At the furthest end was a building two storeys high painted with figures of cypresses, the upper being open and supported on pillars, and having a domed pavilion in the centre. Under the gilt dome, on an elevated polygonal throne, sat the Shah: 'Two attendants holding in their hands the universal ensign of royalty in Asiatic monarchies, chowries [horse-hair fly-whisks], immediately determined the situation to be the same as that which the imagination pictures in reading fairy tales, or the Arabian Nights,' wrote Fraser. 'When we first entered, we made the obeisance required by taking off our hats three times and uniting the hands together, as you would to hold water, held them opposite the bottom of the